

PART II

Community, neighborhoods and impacts on
equality and well-being

6. Increasing community well-being through school-centered neighborhood development: the Community Learning Center Institute in Cincinnati

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INTRODUCTION

Research overwhelmingly shows that neighborhood characteristics impact a child's ability to succeed in school. For example, the recently released report, *Loving Cities*, by the Schott Foundation for Public Education (2020) states that family income and zip code are the most important predictors of educational success. Since the 1960s, scholars and practitioners have agreed that non-school factors are powerful determinants of a child's ability to succeed in school and beyond. Housing, employment, safety, health, recreation, and population turnover, which are linked to chronic absenteeism and student withdrawals, are all neighborhood factors that have been shown to impact student achievement (Berliner, 2009; Coulton et al., 2012; Theodos, 2014). Despite the obvious connections between community well-being and educational quality, planners and developers, on the one hand, and educators on the other continue to operate in separate silos, resulting in missed opportunities for cross-sector collaboration.

The inextricable link between neighborhood and school success is not a new idea. The current community school movement draws ideas from Progressive Era settlement houses that emerged in the 1880s. The settlement houses were a platform for educating inner-city residents so that they could advance socially and economically. Later, in the first couple of decades of the twentieth century, Progressive Era schools served as centers for inner-city neighborhood activities along with settlement houses (Griswold, 2014). Furthermore, schools, as neighborhood centers, were linked to planning practice at the turn of the twentieth century. Ebenezer Howard located a school at the center of each ward in his 1898 garden city design and Clarence Perry (Perry, 1914,

cited in Talen, 2020) advocated that schools should function as neighborhood centers complete with adult education and town forums.

Recent years have witnessed a natural alignment between the community school model and other place-based initiatives. The US Department of Education's Promise Neighborhoods program is a federal place-based initiative striving to turn neighborhoods of concentrated poverty into neighborhoods of opportunity. The program's vision is to ensure that all children growing up in Promise Neighborhoods have access to robust schools, strong families, and community support systems to prepare them to attain an excellent education and to successfully transition to college and a career (Potapchuk, 2013; Urban Institute, 2021).

Recent research on community schools has focused on academic performance in low-income communities (Coalition for Community Schools, 2021). However, except for Griswold's 2014 master's thesis at the University of Toledo, there have been few studies examining the extent to which community schools stimulate broader neighborhood improvements—or the extent to which neighborhood betterment is linked to improved educational outcomes. This chapter addresses this gap in the literature.

Through a Cincinnati case study, we seek to add to the limited literature on linked neighborhood revitalization and school improvement efforts. The Community Learning Center Institute (CLCI) operates six of the Cincinnati Public Schools' (CPS) 45 community learning centers (CLCs). This chapter focuses on one of the six—Oyler CLC—located in the Lower Price Hill (LPH) community.

Focusing on Oyler CLC in LPH, Cincinnati, we seek to answer the following four questions. First, what factors led to the creation of the Oyler CLC? Second, how did CLCI engage community residents to prepare the Lower Price Hill Resurgency Plan (Community Learning Center Institute, 2019) to strengthen the community school? Third, how has CLCI involved other agencies in a neighborhood partnership aimed at implementing the *Resurgency Plan*? Specifically, what types of core competencies have the different public, private, and nonprofit agencies brought to the partnership? And how has CLCI served as the quarterback agency for the revitalization effort? Fourthly, how effective has this cross-sector collaboration been in promoting improved educational and neighborhood revitalization outcomes?

Zdenek and Walsh's 2017 book *Navigating Community Development* has provided us with our conceptual framework to assess CLCI's creation and implementation of a cross-sector partnership. Zdenek and Walsh assume that there are certain core competencies associated with community development and that the lead agency (in this case, CLCI) needs to leverage these competencies through collaboration. These core competencies are: (1) organizational development and management, (2) community engagement, (3) planning,

(4) communication, (5) project development, (6) lending, (7) property asset management, (8) program management, (9) resource development, (10) capital aggregation and fundraising, (11) collaboration and partnering, and (12) performance measurement. We will use this conceptual framework to show how CLCI's partners contributed their unique competencies to enable the partnership to cover six functional areas: (1) vacant property, (2) residential housing, including both homeownership and rental, (3) commercial sector and jobs, (4) beautification, greenspace, and recreation, (5) safety and policing, and (6) neighborhood marketing, branding, and identity.

This chapter relies on interviews of Darlene Kamine, CLCI's Executive Director, and Adelyn Hall, CLCI's Director of School-Centered Neighborhood Development, conducted by David Varady. We also utilize federal census data, Ohio Board of Education information, published documents, and newspaper articles.

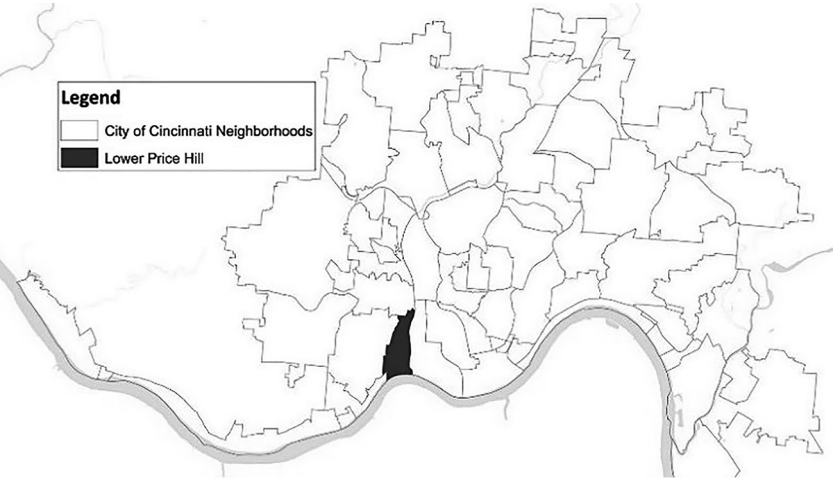
The remainder of this chapter is divided into five parts: (1) the history of LPH, (2) the evolution of Oyler CLC, (3) the *Resurgency Plan*, (4) implementation of the Plan, and (5) conclusion and recommendations.

THE HISTORY OF LOWER PRICE HILL, CINCINNATI

LPH, adjacent to the Ohio River located on the west side of Cincinnati, Ohio (see Figure 6.1), has a rich history as an urban Appalachian,¹ low-income working-class community. Settled by Evans Price in 1819, at its peak between 1940–50, LPH had over 5,000 residents (Social Explorer, 2021) and bustled with manufacturing and heavy industry. With dense, Italianate-style housing (see Figure 6.2), LPH is a Historic District on the National Register of Historic Places in Ohio (Ohio History Connection, 2021).

Between 1970 and 2000, the neighborhood experienced extreme job loss, which resulted in a 75-percent decrease in population. Currently the community has just over 1,000 residents (Social Explorer, 2021).

In his 1991 book *Savage Inequalities* (republished in 2012), Jonathan Kozol highlighted student underachievement at Oyler (85 percent of Oyler's students scored below the national median in reading) as well as the community's poverty, describing LPH as isolated from the rest of the city. Pollutants from nearby factories "cloud[ed] the air". Only 27 percent of adults had a high school diploma. Poor access to decent schools resulted in low test scores and "behavioral issues"; Kozol described the Oyler School as "depleted, bleak, and bare ... and the eyes of the children appear depleted too" (p. 230). By 2000, LPH was considered one of the poorest neighborhoods in Cincinnati, with the highest high school drop-out rate in the city at 62 percent and the second highest functional illiteracy rate at 25 percent (Auffrey & Maloney, 2004).



Source: Author.

Figure 6.1 Lower Price Hill, Cincinnati, Ohio



Source: Author.

Figure 6.2 Lower Price Hill, Cincinnati, Ohio

LPH is still a low-income community, but it has changed from mostly white to racially mixed; 47-percent white, 38-percent black, 12-percent mixed-race, and 2-percent Hispanic. Renters currently make up 84 percent of the neighborhood (American Community Survey, 2021).

EVOLUTION OF THE OYLER COMMUNITY LEARNING CENTER

The Ohio School Facilities Master Plan

In the late 1990s, public schools in Ohio were in dire straits. Enrollment had plummeted, along with the public's trust in the system. The Ohio Supreme Court declared the building conditions in Ohio schools to be so inadequate as to violate the constitutional guarantee for an adequate public education. In 1997, the Ohio School Facilities Commission was formed to assist local districts in building or renovating new facilities. CPS, deemed the worst school district in the state with respect to the physical conditions of the buildings, was put first in line to renovate the schools. CPS and its governing body, the Cincinnati Board of Education (the Board), as well as representatives of the broader community, began exploring options to develop a new strategy for schools, that is, joint use facilities with co-located partnerships, commonly known as community schools (Kamine, 2012; Interview of Kamine by Varady, 9 December 2020).

Under the leadership of the Children's Defense Fund's Director of Education, Darlene Kamine and CPS built support for building or renovating new facilities as CLCs. Through community forums, information sessions, and visits to other cities, local leaders began to embrace the CLC concept (Interview of Kamine by Varady, 9 December 2020).

CPS then hired the Children's Defense Fund to lead the community engagement effort to plan for the new buildings as CLCs. Early work by Kamine, now the Executive Director of the CLCI, included the development of partnerships for the redesigned CLCs in three neighborhoods prior to the launch of the Facilities Master Plan (FMP). In 2003, CPS officially launched the \$1 billion FMP for the rebuilding of all schools as CLCs in the district. While 23 percent of funding came from the State, the majority came from a school-construction bond issue approved by voters in May 2003. This was a major accomplishment because for decades CPS had been unable to pass any tax levy (Kamine, 2012).

In creating the CLCs, CPS sought to adhere to two principles. First, public schools "belong to the public", as they are institutions funded by public tax dollars, and therefore should serve the students, their families, and the surrounding neighborhood alike. Second, CLCs were to be developed in response to genuine, neighborhood by neighborhood community engagement

and managed through site-based governance, carried out by the Local School Decision Making Committee (LSDMC). CPS policy requires each LSDMC to include an even mixture of parents, community members, teachers, and administrators (Kamine, 2012).

From 2002 to 2009, Kamine continued to lead community engagement for the transformation of all schools as CLCs and developed a model for co-located partnerships in community schools led by a Resource Coordinator. All co-located partnerships, as well as the Resource Coordinator, were to be financially independent, meaning funds to pay for the Resource Coordinator and subsequent partners were not to come from CPS's operating budget. Furthermore, all partnerships were to be selected by the LSDMC in response to community engagement.

In 2006, the Cross Boundary Leadership Network (CBLN) was launched, made up of partnership networks aligned with CPS CLCs. These allied networks included a mental health network known as MindPeace, a school-based and vision health network known as Growing Well, and an oral health network known as the Cincinnati Oral Health Network, just to name a few. Still in existence today, the CBLN aims to promote the sustainability of CLC partnerships as the work expands.

During this time, Resource Coordinators and co-located partnerships were funded by the Greater Cincinnati Foundation and United Way, both of which agreed to cover the cost of nine Resource Coordinators for up to four years. Subsequently, both entities agreed to cover the cost of 18 Resource Coordinators on an ongoing basis, with the remainder being funded from federal Title 1 dollars provided by the State of Ohio. Beginning in 2009, the CLCs began to receive national attention from teacher's associations and the community school movement.

The Community Learning Center Institute

In August 2009, the CLCI was formed as a 513(c)3 nonprofit organization, led by Executive Director Darlene Kamine. Created to support and promote the development and sustainability of CLCs in Cincinnati, CLCI aims to create the conditions for learning and catalyze the revitalization of neighborhoods. With the addition of CLCI's advocacy, in 2010 CPS increased the number of CLC schools to 21 schools. Around the same time, it became the first urban school district to earn Ohio's "Effective" ranking for the school year 2009–10. The graduation rate for the district rose from 51 percent in 2000 to 82 percent in 2010 (Ohio Department of Education, 2021a). By 2013, the number of CLCs had grown to 35, with additional support coming from the Haile Foundation. CLCI became the lead agency at six sites.

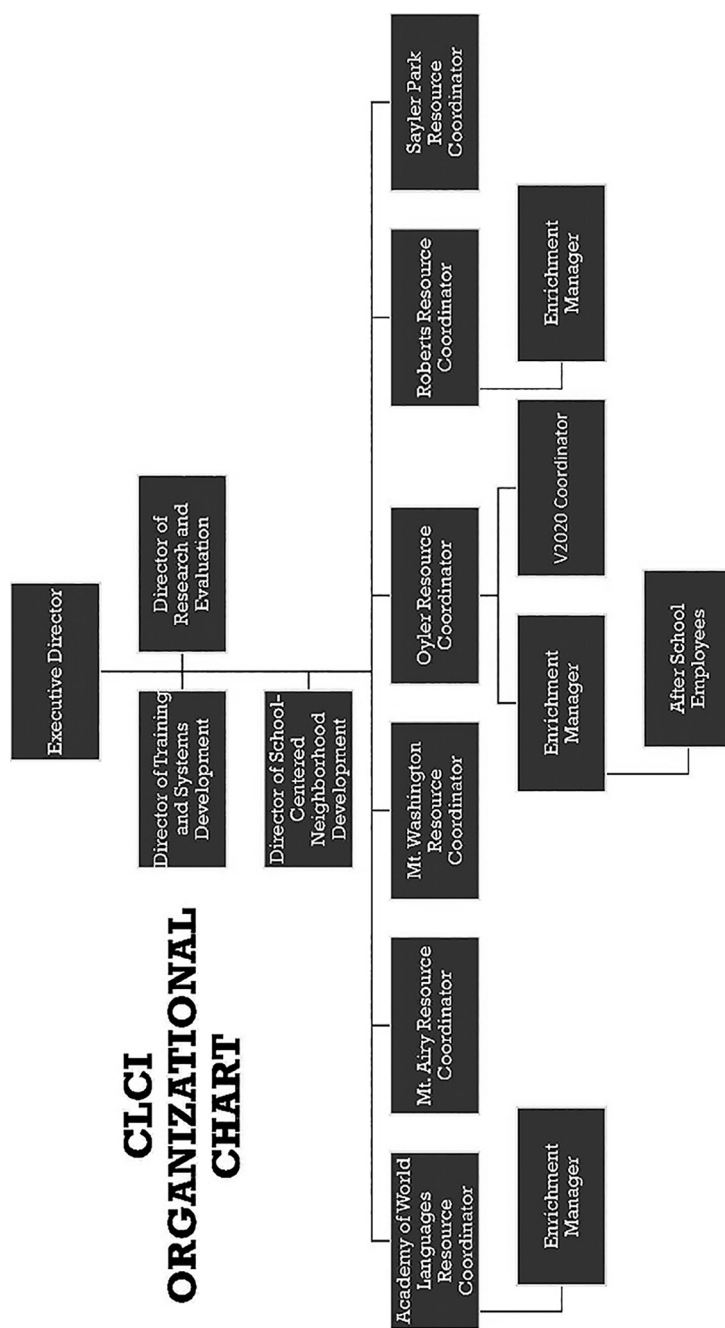
In 2011, CLCI received the National Award of Excellence co-sponsored by US Senate and House of Representative leaders. Recognized as a national model, Cincinnati CLCs became the foundation for the growth of community schools in New York City and Knoxville (Blank, 2012; *Knoxville News Sentinel*, 2011; McAdoo, 2012; *WKRC-TV*, 2011).

Today, 45 out of 66 CPS schools are CLCs (with CLCI acting as the lead agency for six of them), with the goal of all schools becoming CLCs by 2022, as indicated in the CPS Strategic Plan (Cincinnati Public Schools, n.d.). The 45 existing CLCs contain one or more of the following: school-based health centers, full-service vision centers, full-service dental centers, kindergarten readiness centers, co-located mental health partners, and early childhood education providers. Figure 6.3 describes CLCI's organizational structure.

Oyler Community Learning Center

In the early 2000s, Oyler School, built as a K-8 school in the 1930s and located in the center of LPH, was failing. Most of its students never made it to graduation (Auffrey & Maloney, 2004). In 2012, after an extensive community engagement process, Oyler School opened as Oyler CLC. The community engagement process is spelled out in *10 Principles of Community Engagement* (KnowledgeWorks Foundation, 2005) developed by Kamine in conjunction with KnowledgeWorks. The school building now included a high school for the first time in its history. School renovations totaling \$21 million were funded by the FMP. Partnership buildouts included an Oyler Health Center, Delta Dental Center, OneSight Vision Center, the Robert and Adele Schiff Early Learning Center, GRAD Cincinnati (career and higher education counseling), and the Al Hampton Mentoring Center. These partnership buildouts with a combined estimate of \$1.8 million² in capital improvements were funded through a variety of philanthropic resources including, but not limited to, the Robert and Adele Schiff Family Foundation, Delta Dental Foundation, and OneSight Luxottica (Interview of Kamine by Varady, 3 December 2020; Interview of Kamine by Varady, 9 December 2020). Today, Oyler CLC is hailed as the model for community schools (Brookings Institution, 2021; Brown, 2014; Driehaus, 2014; Hernandez, 2013).

CLCI is continuously aiming to increase the use of the CLC as a hub for the neighborhood. Adelyn Hall, Director of School-Centered Neighborhood Development for CLCI, as well as other CLCI staff, engages community residents on an ongoing basis, which includes formal or informal one-on-one meetings with parents, residents, and teachers, as well as large community gatherings located at Oyler CLC. Furthermore, Hall meets with LPH's governing bodies, such as Oyler's LSDMC, LPH's Community Council, and LPH's Neighborhood Alliance of Businesses. In developing her own approach



Source: Author.

Figure 6.3 CLCI organizational chart 2021

to community engagement used in the *Resurgency Plan*, discussed in detail below, Hall drew from the process that Kamine used in preparing the FMP and later in creating CLCs for LPH and elsewhere (CLCI, 2019; Interview of Kamine by Varady, 3 December 2020).

The CLC model does seem to be succeeding for the Cincinnati school system as a whole and for Oyler in particular. First, since the impetus of CPS as CLCs in Cincinnati, CPS has reversed the decline in enrollment, adding more than 1,000 students per year pre-COVID 19,³ and has reversed the decline of some academic indicators. CPS is now one of the top-performing urban districts in the State of Ohio and is the only urban district in the State to see an overall increase in enrollment (Heise-Kult, 2019). On a positive trajectory, CPS' quality and public image appears to be improving and the district is even beginning to attract the types of middle-income families who had previously left the district for other school options.

Turning to the Oyler CLC, since the addition of the high school in 2012, LPH has now graduated more students from the neighborhood in the past nine years than in its entire recorded history.⁴ In the school year 2018–19, Oyler's graduation rate—85.5 percent—surpassed the district's average at 79.4 percent. While the district's graduation rate increased 19.2 percent from 2010–19, Oyler CLC had the highest graduation rate increase of 46 percent from 2010–19 (Sharber, 2020). Despite obstacles related to COVID-19, Oyler CLC achieved its highest graduation rate yet in the year 2019–20 at 93 percent. (The official graduation rate will be released by the Ohio Department of Education in the Fall of 2021.) Furthermore, Oyler graduates had a 57-percent college matriculation rate in 2019–20, up from 26 percent in 2017 (National Student Clearinghouse, 2021).

Third, looking to the younger grades, Oyler's Kindergarten Readiness percentage increased from 54 percent in 2015–16 to 68 percent in 2019–20. Furthermore, 100 percent of third graders met the third-grade reading guarantee in 2019–20 for the first time since testing started in 2017 (Ohio Department of Education, 2021b). Research has been able to show a correlation between improved kindergarten readiness and early childhood programs supported by community schools, such as Learning Grove at Oyler CLC (Loewenberg, 2019).

Fourth, the Ohio Department of Education's Oyler Report Card shows improvements in student mobility (or turnover)—calculated by the total of new student entries and withdrawals during the school year divided by the total enrollment—down from 32 percent in 2015–16 to 18 percent in 2019–20. Students flagged as homeless,⁵ dropped from 12 percent in 2015–16 to 8 percent in 2019–20. And chronic absenteeism decreased from 8 percent in 2015–16 to 6 percent in 2019–20 (2021b).

Beginning around 2015, it was becoming clear that Oyler CLC was making progress inside the four walls of the school. However, the neighborhood of LPH was still in decline. High vacancy rates and subpar housing resulted in high mobility and homelessness rates at Oyler CLC. Kamine noted that the CLC approach to community improvement up to that point had been limited in scope: “Early in the work, it was generally assumed that by lifting the school, the neighborhood would rise as well. That did not happen” (Interview of Kamine, by Varady, 9 December 2020). She believed that a more intentional approach to neighborhood revitalization was needed and in 2015, with the financial support of the Kellogg Foundation, hired Adelyn Hall to be the Director of School-Centered Neighborhood Development for CLCI, ultimately acting as the quarterback for the *Resurgency Plan*.

LOWER PRICE HILL RESURGENCY PLAN

Work on the *Resurgency Plan* began in Spring of 2015 by bringing together neighborhood residents, business owners, various stakeholders, Oyler students, staff, and partners. Structured as a series of engagement workshops—a kickoff meeting, a community mapping meeting, a concept plan review meeting, and an implementation work group meeting—LPH stakeholders and residents gathered inside the Oyler CLC cafeteria to formulate their vision for the future of the neighborhood. Over a series of four community gathering sessions mixed in with countless one-on-one conversations with residents, stakeholder meetings, and parent meetings (such as engagement with parents at the Adele and Robert Schiff Early Learning Center during “parent coffee-hours”) an estimated 164 LPH residents, 42 stakeholder agency staff members, and uncounted Oyler students, teachers, and staff participated in the creation of the *Resurgency Plan*. From start to finish it took about three and a half years to complete. The four core community meetings were spread out over a year and then Hall went to work bringing in developers who were the right match for implementation. Hall and others started implementation of the *Resurgency Plan* prior to it being officially approved by the City, as residents wanted to see proof of its effectiveness before taking it through the official process. The idea was to avoid the fate of past neighborhood plans that sit on a shelf because no effort is made to address the lack of trust between planners and community residents.

At the kickoff meeting for the *Resurgency Plan* an estimated 85 residents and various stakeholders were introduced to the purpose of the planning process and reviewed the history of the neighborhood and the school. Kamine and related stakeholders shared demographic trends, as well as crime and housing statistics. After grounding the conversation in history and relevant facts, as guided by the principles of authentic community engagement written

by Kamine (KnowledgeWorks, 2005), residents engaged in a community mapping activity led by Hall to better understand what existing community assets (health services, social services, parks, greenspace, etc.) were currently available to the neighborhood (Community Learning Center Institute, 2019).

Hall, working with others from the CLCI team, spent four years and countless hours in the facilitation, engagement, and creation of the *Resurgency Plan*. After review by Oyler's LSDMC and approval from the LPH Community Council, the Cincinnati Planning Commission, and Cincinnati City Council, the *Resurgency Plan* was officially approved on 17 April 2019.

Hall has played a key role in producing the plan and in implementing it as well. Using Zdenek and Walsh's (2017) terminology she is the "quarterback", the dedicated staff person provided by CLCI that acts as the lynch pin between LPH stakeholders, the *Resurgency Plan*, and developers. Without her, CLCI would not have been able to focus to the degree it has on implementation, ultimately guaranteeing a focus on implementation of the *Resurgency Plan* that otherwise would probably not have been possible.

In fact, the *Resurgency Plan* has had a meaningful impact on the community. Since the renovation of Oyler School into Oyler CLC (costing around \$22 million), the community has attracted \$109 million of capital investment. Furthermore, it is estimated that an additional \$30 million will be invested in the community by the end of 2022 (Community Learning Center Institute, 2019; Interview of Kamine by Varady, 3 December 2020). Rising property values show that the community is moving in the right direction. LPH has experienced nearly a doubling (107 percent) of industrial property in the past three years. During the same period, residential property values have increased by 14 percent (Wartman, 2021). Abundant qualitative evidence is available (to be discussed in the next section), showing other types of community improvement: a reduction in vacant properties, more homeownership opportunities, more blue-collar jobs, and greater access to health services and healthy foods.

IMPLEMENTATION OF THE LOWER PRICE HILL RESURGENCY PLAN

Vacant Properties

CLCI's concern about housing issues stemmed from the impact of vacant properties on school enrollment. Families and students live in school attendance boundaries. If there is an increase in vacancy, a decline in occupied housing, or an increase in housing units that are so subpar that families cannot live in them, eventually it will be impossible to sustain a neighborhood school at all because it would lack adequate enrollment. In 2012, the year Oyler officially opened as a CLC, the vacancy rate in LPH was 39 percent, that is, roughly two-fifths of

properties in LPH were vacant. Oyler's Principal noted: "Every time a house gets boarded up, we lose a family" (Interview of Hall by Varady, 3 December 2020). The Principal's charge indicated that CLCI needed to promote community revitalization as much as it was already fostering improved education.

It was not only population loss that was a problem. Vacant properties can contribute to other problems, including street crime. When criminals see that no one lives on a street to observe and report crime, they will be more likely to break the law. CLCI's challenge was to promote the development of these properties to decrease crime.

Hall turned to The Port of Greater Cincinnati Development Authority (The Port), manager of Hamilton County Landbank, for help in dealing with the vacant properties. The Port agreed to partner with CLCI to come up with solutions; however, The Port requested a neighborhood plan to be the first step to galvanize the community under a singular plan of action. The Port's role was to act as a security feature working on the front lines, making sure that the community had properties in place, ready to be developed. In 2015, The Port joined the *Resurgency Plan* Steering Committee and was an active member working on the *Resurgency Plan*. The *Resurgency Plan* was approved by the City in April of 2019 after a three-and-a-half-year process.

Table 6.1, the Core Competencies Matrix, shows the core skills that The Port contributed to the revitalization effort: lending, property and asset management, resource development, capital aggregation, and fundraising, and finally, collaboration and partnerships. Hall has been able to take advantage of The Port's core competencies through her own networking, that is, getting them to work with her effectively. Without the personal relationships she has developed, The Port might have focused elsewhere. Hall's philosophy is "to let experts be experts". She has developed a proliferation of partnerships because everyone is there for a reason.

They all serve their purpose; it is because they are an expert in that field. Thus, when the land bank acquires property, they hold the property until an end user is identified (usually through advocacy of CLCI and other neighborhood stakeholders) and then they let that expert develop that property. According to Hall, her job is like a maestro. "My job is to get everyone in lock step, progressing towards the same goal" (Interview of Hall by Varady, 3 December 2020).

Residential Housing: Homeownership

Currently, new projects are being planned and implemented by a variety of partners with *Resurgency Plan* goals in mind. For example, Habitat for Humanity has acquired nine vacant properties in the neighborhood with the goal of renovating them into safe, quality, affordable homes. Thus far, three

Table 6.1 Core competencies matrix

Competency	The Quarterback	Vacant Properties	Residential Housing	Commercial Sector & Jobs	Beautification, Greenspace, & Recreation	Safety & Policing	Branding, Marketing, & Identity
Organizational Development & Management	X						
Community Engagement	X			X		X	
Planning & Public Policy	X					X	
Communications	X				X		X
Project Development (Real Estate)	X		X	X			
Lending		X		X			
Property & Asset Management		X	X	X	X		
Program/Business Line				X			
Development & Management			X	X			
Resource Development, Capital Aggregation, & Fundraising	X	X	X	X	X		
Collaboration & Partnerships	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Performance Measurements & Evaluation	X						

properties have been matched with families and construction completed. In addition, CLCI has acquired a property across the street from Oyler School, commonly known as Oyler House, and remodeled it as an extension of the Oyler Campus to support growing partnerships for the school and community alike.

Homeownership has been one of Hall's main focuses, as homeownership was identified as the community's top priority in the *Resurgency Plan*. There was consensus among those who participated in the planning process that an increase in homeownership would reduce residential turnover leading to an improvement in the educational performance of Oyler students.⁶ Those who worked on the *Resurgency Plan* wanted to attract local partners and resources that could help existing renters in the community become homeowners. The challenge for CLCI was how to simultaneously eliminate vacant properties and provide homeownership opportunities given the fact that the housing stock consists of mainly multi-family rentals in poor condition and the high costs of renovating such historic, yet blighted, buildings.

The Habitat for Humanity model is ideally suited to foster homeownership in communities such as LPH. The model combines low-cost mortgages (made possible by a combination of foundation grants and sweat equity by householders who participate) plus a rigorous training program to prepare families for homeownership.⁷

Habitat, which had been operating in East Price Hill, came to LPH through chance. Habitat staff were bringing program flyers to Oyler CLC at a time when an LPH family was in need of assistance, dealing with being displaced from their home. Hall met the family at the school and informed them about Habitat for Humanity. Hall recalls saying,

For what you are paying in rent, you could easily pay a Habitat for Humanity mortgage. He was like a deer in headlights ... he had never thought about owning his own home. The thought of owning felt totally out of his grasp. The family is now a Habitat owner in East Price Hill. (Interview of Hall by Varady, 3 December 2020)

The episode indicates the value of having the school-based hub of services. The physical proximity of the hub made it possible to easily link Habitat, CLCI, and social service agencies. Hall successfully used this family's achievement to advocate for extending Habitat's work to LPH. So far, Habitat has acquired five properties from The Port's land bank and five properties from private donations. Hall and Kamine secured private funding from local foundations to close the subsidy gap, the difference between the high costs of renovating these buildings and the limited ability of families to repay these costs through their mortgage payments.

We shift now to Price Hill Will, CLCI's second partner in promoting homeownership. Price Hill Will is the community development corporation (CDC) for LPH, East Price Hill, and West Price Hill. CLCI is currently in the process of working with Price Hill Will to expand their urban homesteading program already in existence in East Price Hill to LPH. This affordable homeownership program is quite different from Habitat's. First, Price Hill Will acquires a home from The Port's land bank and then brings it up to code. Price Hill Will then works with two community partners, Santa Maria Community Services and Working in Neighborhoods, to vet the families, making sure they qualify for this program and that they have the funds to handle finances. Once a family is ready to become a homeowner they are then matched to a home and sign a lease-to-own contract with Price Hill Will, under which they pay 25 percent of their income for leasing their home. The payment is towards the mortgage. Also, as part of the contract, they agree to make certain improvements on the home (e.g., landscaping, roof work). The contract lasts five years. After those five years, the family owns that home outright. As of now Price Hill Will has acquired one property from The Port's land bank to start the program and is currently focusing on fund raising to make the needed renovations.

Habitat for Humanity and Price Hill Will bring several core capacities to the table. For Habitat, the most obvious one is project development and real estate management. They acquire the property, they develop the property, and they get the funding. They have a small construction crew, and they have an impressive volunteer component. Habitat is also strong with respect to resource development, capital aggregation, and fund raising. They can fund these projects and bring a lot of their own resources to the projects. A lot of that comes from in-kind volunteer work. Habitat has a well-deserved reputation for its volunteers. Collaboration and partnership are a final core competency.⁸

Price Hill Will brings project development and property and asset management to the table. Furthermore, they are successful in resource development, capital aggregation, and funding, particularly as it relates City funding through Community Development Block Grants. Finally, they are willing collaborators and partners.

Residential Housing: Rental Housing

The Model Group, a well-renowned local private for-profit affordable housing developer, is currently applying for Low Income Housing and Historic Tax Credits (LIHTCs) to renovate a scattered site development in LPH consisting of 18 properties and containing 81 affordable housing units. The Model Group is also committed to improving the retail sector, as they plan to renovate all its first-floor properties located in the neighborhood business district into viable stores geared towards neighborhood use.

As part of the *Resurgency Plan* effort, CLCI turned to The Model Group to address affordable rental housing needs because The Model Group had, prior to the preparation of the *Resurgency Plan*, developed 81 units of affordable rental housing now managed by Preservation of Affordable Housing Inc. (POAH). Currently, CLCI is working with The Model Group, POAH, and the Ohio Housing Finance Agency to secure funding for the unit upgrades, as well as the conversion of first-floor units to commercial space.

In a second effort, Over-the-Rhine Community Housing (OTRCH) is partnering with another nonprofit agency in LPH called Community Matters (CM). Around 2015, CM acquired 20 properties in LPH and needed a development partner to rehabilitate them. CM linked up with OTRCH because of its reputation as an effective nonprofit housing developer and because the Italianate buildings in Over-the-Rhine resembled the buildings in LPH. At the same time, OTRCH staff felt a need to extend their target area from Over-the-Rhine to LPH, about two miles to the west, since Over-the-Rhine's available housing stock has decreased due to rapid gentrification. OTRCH has secured funding from OHFA's LIHTC program, as well as a variety of other sources, to renovate nine vacant buildings and to add one new construction in-fill project, collectively referred to as "Lower Price Hill Thrives". Construction is expected to start in August 2021 and be completed in early 2023. With all the affordable homeownership and rental projects combined, the vacancy rate in the neighborhood will fall by half, to about 15 percent.

Commercial Sector and Jobs

One of the biggest success stories in LPH since the passage of the *Resurgency Plan* has been its ability to drive economic development through the attraction and retention of its industrial workforce. According to Hall,

We have been successful in not only attracting businesses, but then getting Oyler families connected to those now available jobs. Oyler CLC partners work with families directly to identify their career goals and then connect with local companies to plug them into a paid position. It is the best of all possible outcomes. (Interview of Hall by Varady, 3 December 2020)

Nehemiah Manufacturing, a second-chance employer with an estimated 200 employees and growing, combined its facilities through a new construction project in a brownfield site in LPH in 2019 (The Port, 2017). Nehemiah is expanding to a nearby vacant lot in LPH. Construction is expected to begin at the end of 2021. Furthermore, Tri-State Wholesale Building Supplies, McAndrews Glass, OPieO, and others have recently relocated their businesses to LPH. This has resulted in a 107 percent increase in the value of industrial

property in the neighborhood, the largest increase seen throughout the City of Cincinnati, as well as Hamilton County (Wartman, 2021).

During the engagement part of the *Resurgency Plan*, economic development—bringing jobs to the neighborhood—was an extremely high priority. However, the community wanted light industrial companies, ones that would not have a negative impact on the environment. Through the efforts of CLCI and other agencies, such as The Port, LPH has been successful in attracting desirable employers to the neighborhood and then working with Oyler CLC social service agencies to connect LPH residents to job opportunities. These economic development efforts are one reason why LPH has seen a decrease in unemployment, dropping from its high of 26 percent in 2015 to 18 percent in 2019 (American Community Survey, 2021).

With the momentum of Nehemiah and others moving into LPH and then Oyler having relationships with the businesses, CLCI facilitated the creation of the LPH Neighborhood Alliance of Businesses (the Alliance) in 2019. Currently, leadership from Nehemiah Manufacturing, Kroger Manufacturing, Consolidated Metal Products, Inc., and McAndrews Glass make up the Alliance's Executive Board. Hall serves as Secretary for the Alliance. The Alliance brings several core competencies to the table. The first is communications. The Alliance does a good job making sure that the business community is cohesive, and that positive publicity is being disseminated about the neighborhood. The second is property and asset management: the businesses are involved in neighborhood development in the business district. Third, the Alliance has resource development, capital aggregation and fund raising, because the Alliance is exceptionally good at bringing in dollars to the table. And finally, the Alliance promotes collaboration and partnerships because Alliance members see all these businesses coming together to bring about positive change.

Price Hill Will, LPH's only functioning CDC, also partnered with CLCI to acquire, renovate, and restore a cluster of three retail buildings and an adjoining vacant lot to renovate Meiser's Market, a 70-year-old local business. Meiser's Fresh Grocery was awarded a total of \$700,000 by the City of Cincinnati's Community and Economic Development Department through Community Development Block Grants between 2017–19 and opened in the summer of 2021. This project will eliminate a building vacancy, provide jobs, bring in a much-needed store, and provide healthier food options, such as fresh fruits and vegetables, into the neighborhood. Meiser's Fresh Grocery will operate as a nonprofit grocery store. The idea of a nonprofit grocery store is new and there are few examples across the United States. One example, "The Daily Table", was created by the founder of Trader Joe's, set up as a pilot program in Dorchester, Boston in 2015 and is now its own entity. If successful, Meiser's Fresh Grocery could be a model to solve food deserts citywide and beyond.

Hall's biggest frustration with respect to neighborhood revitalization is that it takes so much time. Referring to revitalization in communities like LPH, Hall notes:

It is not something where you just flip a switch ... it is a balancing act between the small wins and the big wins and making sure that momentum builds. No one should give the impression that this is all going to change overnight. (Interview of Hall by Varady, 3 December 2020)

Beautification, Green Space, and Recreation

Green space and recreational opportunities have been greatly expanded in the neighborhood through partnerships with Learning Grove (a nonprofit early childhood education agency that partners with Oyler CLC), the Cincinnati Red's Community Fund, the Cincinnati Zoo, and the City of Cincinnati's Community and Economic Development Department. Several green initiatives called for in the neighborhood planning process have been implemented. For example, Evans Baseball Field and Park was renovated to include dugouts and bleachers and the nearby playground now includes a much-desired skate park. Learning Grove renovated a vacant lot adjacent to the school as an early learning center nature playscape, coupled with programming by Learning Grove, Cincinnati Public Libraries, and the Cincinnati Zoo. CM partnered with the Cincinnati Reds Community Fund and created a large community garden known as Sassafras Garden. Groundwork Ohio River Valley (a nonprofit conservation agency that partners with Oyler CLC with a special focus on youth employment) facilitates Oyler's "Green Team", which works on expanding greenspace throughout the neighborhood while educating LPH youth. Finally, the Ohio River West Working Group (an all-volunteer resident-led group that focuses on expanding urban trails throughout the west side of Cincinnati), along with the City of Cincinnati, has just completed the neighborhood's first urban bike trail, commonly referred to as the "O-Trail". Oyler CLC is partnering with Groundwork Ohio River Valley and Red Bike (Cincinnati's bikeshare system) to create Oyler's first hike and bike club, to ensure that Oyler students are familiar with proper bike handling and can utilize the trail for their own enjoyment.

Safety and Policing

LPH is perceived as a high crime area. The *Resurgency Plan* identified safety as a high priority for the community and listed reducing crime, improving youth and police relations, and reducing youth violence as three of its main goals. Strategies to reduce crime thus far have included the addition of a Community

Police Officer in LPH, the reduction of blight and vacancy through the addition of community gardens and green space, community-organized good guy loitering events, and the LPH Collaboration to Prevent Violence, which is funded by the City of Cincinnati and brings together residents, police officers, and community stakeholders (including the school) in order to provide solutions to chronic crime issues in the neighborhood. Statistics show that crime has decreased by 25 percent from 2015–21 (City of Cincinnati Performance and Data Analytics, 2021a, 2021b), although it is suspected that crime is still underreported in the community.

Community-based organizations must work with the police to counter the impression that there is a crime problem in the community. The Cincinnati Police Department's ShotSpotter program has made a difference in reducing crime in LPH. Technical equipment has been installed that covers most of the neighborhood, and when shots are fired this is automatically reported. This removes the need for personal reporting. Incidents get signaled to the police and then they respond. In addition, various businesses and community stakeholders have assisted crime reduction efforts as they have collaborated and taken on the onus of reporting incidents to the police, something that residents have continually expressed a hesitancy to do. Ultimately, crime is likely to continue to go down as the vacancy rate drops, and as more eyes on the street result in a decrease in opportunistic crime.

Neighborhood Marketing, Branding, and Identity

Neighborhood marketing, branding, and identity is carried out through the collaboration of local officials working together to create a positive perception of the neighborhood. For example, Nehemiah Manufacturing's marketing team worked with Oyler CLCs seventh- and eighth-grade students in a year-long education program where the students came up a new logo for the neighborhood and a new tagline, "LPH on the Rise" (see Figure 6.4). Not only did these students receive a first-class education in marketing and design, but the neighborhood also obtained, without cost, an upgraded logo that captures the pride of the community. The Alliance and the LPH Community Council now uses this logo for all correspondence. Furthermore, the logo will be permanently displayed on a neighborhood business district sign to be installed by the City in the summer of 2021. This unique collaboration to create the LPH logo was captured in the short film series *On the Rise: Cincinnati's Community Learning Centers* in episode six entitled "Rebranding LPH Together" (Partnership for the Future of Learning, 2019).

These marketing efforts have begun to improve the community's image. Recently, the American Planning Association (APA) gave an Ohio Great Places Award to Oyler CLC (American Planning Association Ohio Chapter,



Source: Author.

Figure 6.4 Lower Price Hill neighborhood logo

2020). Through this recent award, the APA has featured LPH alongside other renowned sites and neighborhoods in Cincinnati, such as Findlay Market in Over-the-Rhine and Hyde Park Square in the neighborhood of Hyde Park.

CONCLUSION

CLCI's work in transforming schools as CLCs with a particular focus on school-centered neighborhood development has proven to result in positive academic outcomes, such as an increase in graduation and college matriculation, as well as a decrease in homelessness, chronic absenteeism, and mobility. Furthermore, Oyler CLC has catalyzed the revitalization of LPH through increased reinvestments and leveraging of partnerships, which has so far resulted in positive neighborhood outcomes, such as decreased vacancy, unemployment, and crime.

The success of CLCI's neighborhood revitalization efforts can be attributed to: (1) the quarterback role performed by CLCI's Director of School-Centered Neighborhood Development, who focuses on community engagement and horizontal relations at the neighborhood level, (2) cross-sector partnerships covering core competencies (see Table 6.1), and (3) the leadership role performed by CLCI's Executive Director, who has been responsible for bringing in significant external funding which in turn has helped to maintain CLCI's independence. Ultimately, CLCI's community school model is an innovative and holistic approach that improves social equity, community well-being, and quality of life for many of Cincinnati's children and families.

NOTES

1. Urban Appalachians are people from Appalachia (made up of 420 counties across 13 states, from southern New York to northern Mississippi), who are living in metropolitan areas outside of the region. Because migration has been occurring for decades, most are not first-generation migrants from the region, but are descendants of migrants and are long-term city dwellers (Appalachian Regional Commission, 2021). Urban Appalachians are considered a protected class in the City of Cincinnati (City of Cincinnati City Law Department, 2020).
2. Adjusted for inflation.
3. For 2020–21, CPS estimated a 5,000-student enrollment loss due to COVID-19. However, CPS predicts that the school district will gain this enrollment back with the return of in-person schooling and higher enrollment in kindergarten next school year.
4. Prior to Oyler High School, LPH students were sent to high school outside of the neighborhood, such as West High in Western Hills, Cincinnati.
5. The federal McKinney-Vento law defines the homeless as individuals who do not have a fixed, regular, and adequate home because they have lost their own home.
6. There is considerable social science research showing that homeowners are more engaged in civic life and vote more often than renters, and that their children do better in schools. However, few of these studies demonstrate why owners are more likely to have these desirable traits (see for example, US Department of Housing and Urban Development, 1995, and Quercia et al., 2011).
7. For a more detailed discussion of Habitat for Humanity see Applied Real Estate Analysis Inc. (1998).
8. It is important to note, however, that a full accounting of Habitat for Humanity resources should consider contributions made available to Habitat via the *Resurgency Plan*. CLCI's community engagement process quarterbacked by Hall made Habitat for Humanity aware of what the community wanted, which enabled Habitat to figure out how they could fit into the revitalization strategy.

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